security – and motherly love – which Baumann was able to provide. The daughter of a bricklayer, she was born in the working-class district of Prenzlauer Berg in 1909. While working as a typist, she joined the SPD in 1927 and belonged to the Socialist Workers' Youth. During the Nazi era, she served three years in prison and after 1945 was attracted to the KPD but joined the SPD to promote the idea of a unified party. After the KPD-SPD merger, she joined the SED executive, helping to set up youth committees alongside Honecker, as his deputy.

After months of courting, marriage followed. Honecker lost no time in demonstrating his credentials as a family man when Edith presented him with a daughter, Erica, in 1948. They moved into a handsome apartment at 12 Puderstraße, an elegant lane in Treptow, opposite the Russian memorial dedicated to Soviet soldiers lost in the battle for Berlin. 'Baumann's influence on him was positive in every respect,' Heinz Lippmann recounted. Increasingly self-assured, he 'looked better groomed and had more poise than before'. Her influence also stretched to the workplace, where decisions concerning his staff – especially those involving the disciplining of other officials 'were often made less harsh or obviated altogether by Baumann. At that time, Honecker made the impression of a very unassuming man who lived quite unostentatiously.' Life at Puderstraße was a time of happiness. He loved playing skat, a trick-taking card game with bidding, and, like Edith, adored films, theatre and dining out. In restaurants, he derived 'childish pleasure' by wolfing two full dishes of pig's trotters while his friends struggled with the first course. He had the constitution of a cockroach but as many comrades were afloat on a sea of alcohol, Honecker stuck to the occasional beer and avoided spirits. He rarely became snappish but detested the countless vodka toasts at official receptions. 'He was usually ill after these affairs,' Lippmann noted.21 Wolfgang Ghantus, a government translator, recollected Honecker's weakness for American filter cigarettes:

When I first met him in 1950, he offered me a Camel ciggy. Back then he was still puffing away like a chimney. He had no knowledge of foreign languages, which surprised me because he